

CASE ID: 201010710385

EPISODE NAME: Nobel Prize for Liu Xiaobo

2010/10/12 - 2016/12/19

Sender: China (710)

Target: Norway (385)

Issue: Terminate Support of Non-State Actors (10)

Final Outcome: Partial Acquiescence by the Target State following sanctions imposition (6)

Narrative:

On 2010/10/12, China targeted Norway with economic and diplomatic sanctions after imprisoned Chinese dissident Liu Xiaobo was awarded the 2010 Nobel Peace Prize.¹ Liu Xiaobo was sentenced to 11 years in prison for inciting the subversion of state power in 2009.² He was among the co-authors of Charter 08, a document calling for reforms in China.³ The prize was announced on 2010/10/08.⁴

The episode began on 2010/10/12, when Ma Zhaoxu, spokesman for the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, vaguely threatened that the Norwegian Nobel Committee's decision to award Liu the Nobel would "damage bilateral relations" between China and Norway.⁵

Although China never formally announced sanctions against Norway, China suspended bilateral government contracts and placed negotiations for a free trade agreement on hold directly after the incident.⁶ Later research also demonstrated that Norwegian fish exports to China were reduced by between \$125 and \$176 million from 2011-2013 as a result of the spat, and total exports fell by between \$780 and \$1300 million.⁷

The episode ended on 2016/12/19, when Norwegian Foreign Minister Boerge Brende announced that the two countries would resume negotiating the free-trade deal.⁸ The

¹ "Nobel Peace Prize awarded to China dissident Liu Xiaobo." *BBC News*, 8 Oct. 2010.

<https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-11499098>

² "China Anger at 'farce' of Liu Xiaobo Nobel Peace Prize." *BBC News*, December 10th, 2010. www.bbc.com/news/world-asia-pacific-11974187.

³ Ibid.

⁴ "Nobel Peace Prize awarded to China dissident Liu Xiaobo." *BBC News*, 8 Oct. 2010. <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-europe-11499098>

⁵ Jiang, Steven. "China Warns Nobel Prize Will Damage Relations with Norway." *CNN*, October 13th, 2010.

www.cnn.com/2010/WORLD/asiapcf/10/12/china.nobel.reaction/index.html?iref=mpstoryview#:~:text=From%20Steven%20Jiang%20and%20Jo.also%20reveals%20their%20true%20intentions.

⁶ Sverdrup-Thygeson, Bjørnar, and Lanteigne, Marc. "China and Norway: Unpacking the Deal." *The Diplomat*, December 25th, 2016. thediplomat.com/2016/12/china-and-norway-unpacking-the-deal/.

⁷ Kolstad, Ivar. "Too big to fault? effects of the 2010 Nobel peace prize on Norwegian exports to China and foreign policy." *International Political Science Review*, vol. 41, no. 2, January 10th, 2019, pp. 207–223. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0192512118808610>.

⁸ "Norway, China Normalize Ties after Nobel Peace Prize Row." *Reuters*, December 19th, 2016. www.reuters.com/article/world/norway-china-normalize-ties-after-nobel-peace-prize-row-idUSKBN1480R4/.

actual diplomatic concessions made by each party in the joint statement issued by Norway and China were vague.⁹ However, the Norwegian government did appear to accept some culpability for the incident, as the joint statement indicated that Oslo would “do its best to avoid future damage to bilateral relations.”¹⁰ Later research also revealed that Norwegian alignment with Chinese voting decisions on UN human rights resolutions increased.¹¹

⁹ Sverdrup-Thygeson, Bjørnar, and Lanteigne, Marc. “China and Norway: Unpacking the Deal.” *The Diplomat*, December 25th, 2016. thediplomat.com/2016/12/china-and-norway-unpacking-the-deal/.

¹⁰ Sverdrup-Thygeson, Bjørnar, and Lanteigne, Marc. “China and Norway: Unpacking the Deal.” *The Diplomat*, December 25th, 2016. thediplomat.com/2016/12/china-and-norway-unpacking-the-deal/.

¹¹ Kolstad, Ivar. “Too big to fault? effects of the 2010 Nobel peace prize on Norwegian exports to China and foreign policy.” *International Political Science Review*, vol. 41, no. 2, January 10th, 2019, pp. 207–223. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0192512118808610>.